

frozen state until something comes along that will be able to cure him. In this, the 21st century, cryonics may really reach perfection. The list of ideas that technology has in store for the direct betterment of human life is endless!

Nanotechnology

You hear news about nanotech all the time—a new kind of fibre that will prevent socks from smelling, or a full-fledged guitar that can only be viewed through a microscope. Make no mistake about this: such news is only the beginning, and nanotech is certainly not dedicated to the manufacturing of interesting but useless products. It's the direct manipulation of things on the atomic or molecular level, and who can say what's not possible with that? Nanotechnology, all by itself, can be called the technology of the 21st century.

Synthetic bones. Metal rubber. Nanocrystals that make metals harder. Stain-resistant cloth. Automotive lubricants. High-power rocket propellants. OLED screens. There's no area of life that nanotech does not find a place in!

Information Retrieval

The 21st century, is the century of information, and, naturally, information overload. We're repeating ourselves when we say there's too much information around, but it cannot be overstated. Mature technologies that will help us sift through all this data are the need of the hour.

The last five years have seen truly dramatic improvements in search technology, and arti-



Will any search or information retrieval tool ever dethrone Google? It doesn't matter though, because regardless of which company does it, searching with the help of AI is still an exciting concept

cial intelligence is one of several methods that will make search better and faster.

Data mining—finding useful patterns in masses of data—is rapidly maturing, and companies such as airlines, for example, will soon be able to make precise observations about the huge piles of customer data they have. The goal, ultimately, is to be able to quickly get meaningful answers to ques-

tions for which we already have the data.

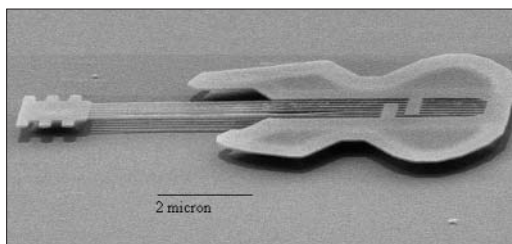
If you need to know what car best suits your needs, your computer— or whatever it will be called—should be able to give you one answer with complete confidence. You should just need to key in your criteria. Going by current trends and the amount of research being done on information retrieval, such a scenario is not far off.

Exciting Times

What you've seen in this article is just a taste of the things to come. One could write tomes on the amount of research being conducted in each field of technology—and we'd need a two-thousand page issue of *Digit* to cover that! Some of the technologies we've mentioned have already been looked at in previous issues of *Digit*, and the ones that haven't, we'll cover in upcoming issues.

So far, technology certainly has changed our lives for the better, and will continue to make life easier in the near future. There's no doubt that this generation is living to see some of the most exciting times, and is witnessing more advancements than any other. Look forward to future issues of *Digit* to read up on the enhancements to these technologies—as well as the emergence of newer ones that will impact our daily lives in some way or the other. ■

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With nanotechnology, you can literally manipulate matter at atomic levels. The guitar above is just 10 microns long (about the size of a cell), with strings that are just 100 atoms wide!

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